

Ease Your Ubuntu Experience

So you have made the leap, and are flying away from Windows... welcome to Ubuntu! You must have performed a few common activities like using the Ubuntu Software Centre, installing media codecs and drivers for your graphics card, etc. So what's next? This article offers tips on how to make your work on Ubuntu 10.10 Maverick Meerkat faster, and more convenient.



In this article, I have seven tips for you, which I have found very helpful in my daily usage of Ubuntu. Without much ado, let's get right into them.

Install Synapse, a fast, light application launcher

Forgot, or don't want to remember, what sub-menu your favourite application is in? Use an application launcher instead! A little window that appears on pressing a key combination, it lets you search for an 'activity' and press *Enter* to launch it. If you've forgotten the name of the application, you can even enter a semantically-related term: for example, 'web', 'internet', or 'browser', for the Firefox browser; 'word' or 'word processor' for OpenOffice Writer; 'spreadsheet' for... you get it!

App launchers abound, but I'll suggest Synapse (see Figure 1). It's light, fast, and easy to use, as well as a small download (less than 1 MB!). You'll need to tell Ubuntu where to find Synapse, since it's not available by default. In Ubuntu Software Centre, click *Edit* > *Software Sources*. Enter your password when prompted, click *Add* and issue the following command:

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ppa:synapse-core/ppa
```

Click *Add Source*. Back in Software Centre, click the *Reload* button. After reloading, search for, and install the

synapse package. I recommend you also install *zeitgeist*, which gives Synapse the smarts to list commonly/recently used applications, thus tailoring the list to suit your daily usage.

Once both are installed, add Synapse to your GNOME *Startup Applications*, so it will start automatically when you log in. Go to the *System* menu > *Preferences* > *Startup Applications*. Click *Add*. In the *Name* entry, type '*Synapse app launcher*' or any short name you choose; in the *Command* entry, enter '*synapse*' (both without the quotes). Click the *Add* button and you're done.

From your next log-in onwards, you just hit *Ctrl+Spacebar* to activate Synapse. You can see what it looks like in Figure 1.

Speed up OpenOffice

OpenOffice could be faster (couldn't everything?). To reduce the time it takes to open, add the *OpenOffice Quickstarter* to *Startup Applications*, using the procedure explained above, but change the Name to '*OOo Quickstarter*' and the *Command* to '*ooffice -quickstart*'. From your next log-in onwards, when you launch an OpenOffice component, you'll see that it opens faster than before—because it is pre-loaded when you're logging in. This does consume some memory, and slows down your log-in a little, so depending